CHAPTER ONE

The First Step

Courage does not always arrive as a grand decision. Sometimes it is the quiet act of opening the notebook you have avoided, making the call you have postponed, or admitting that the familiar path no longer fits.

On the first morning, Mira did not change her life. She cleared a corner of her desk. She put a glass of water beside an empty page and wrote one honest sentence. It was not impressive. It was a beginning.

For months she had waited for certainty. She imagined that confidence would arrive first and action would follow. Instead, the smallest action gave her something certainty never had: evidence that she could move.

There were still reasons to hesitate. Her work was unfinished, her time was limited, and other people seemed further ahead. None of those things disappeared when she began. They simply stopped making every decision for her.

THE QUIET COURAGE

She chose a promise she could keep: ten minutes at the desk each morning. On a difficult day, ten minutes was enough. On an easier day, she stayed longer. The habit grew because it belonged to her actual life.

Progress became easier to recognise when she stopped demanding a transformation. A paragraph revised. A question asked. A boundary spoken gently. Each small act was a way of saying that her attention mattered.

At the end of the week she read the pages again. They were imperfect, but they existed. She could improve a sentence that existed. She could not improve the unwritten book she had been carrying in her head.

The next step did not require a different person. It required the person she already was to return, with patience, to the work in front of her.

> Small steps count.
> Especially the ones nobody sees.